



Homecoming: Roland Butcher displays the Union flag luggage label on his arrival at the Heathrow airport on January 15, 1981.

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another adjustment. It took a while, but eventually, I adapted and developed a passion for football, even more so than cricket, because we were always playing football.

It was through football that I got into cricket. On weekends, kids from the area would go to the local park, make makeshift goals, and play football for hours. One Sunday, after playing football for three hours, some guys came onto the field to set up a cricket match. They were short on players and asked if any of us wanted to join. Initially, I was reluctant, but my best friend in the UK, who was English, persuaded me to play. I ran home, told my mother, and went back to the park to play. I didn't do anything fantastic — I scored about 12 runs and took a couple of catches — but to my surprise, they invited me to play the following week.

This was the local third XI for Stevenage. I thought they wanted me to play because they were short of players, but soon I moved up to the second XI, and, by age 15, I was playing in the first XI. My development in cricket started from there.

Reflecting on your Test debut in 1981, what was the emotional experience of playing for a different country in Barbados like?

Going on that tour was a formidable challenge because the West Indies were by far the most dominant team in world cricket. It was a bigger challenge for me because I was a black West Indian returning to the West Indies to play against the West Indies. The first Test match was in Trinidad, but I didn't play there. The second Test match was in Guyana, and I was due to play, but then the Robin Jackman affair happened. Bob Willis got injured and was replaced by Robin Jackman, but his entry permit was revoked by the Guyanese government because of his prior visits to South Africa, which was under apartheid at the time.

This didn't sit well in the Caribbean. Jackman was asked to leave, and the British Foreign Office and the English Cricket Board decided that if he had to leave, the whole team would leave. So, the Test match was cancelled, and we moved on to Barbados, which was going to be the third Test but became the second.

I made my debut in Barbados, the place of my birth and where I had seen my very first Test match. On day two of my first Test match, our assistant manager Ken Barrington had a heart attack and passed away, making it more challenging to focus on the game while dealing with the loss of a team member. That first Test match went from excitement to sadness very quickly.

At the time, I didn't fully understand the significance because I was focused on fulfilling my ambition to play international cricket. Later in life, you get wiser and understand the political implications and historical significance of what happened. Being the first black player motivated others.

Suddenly, they felt that if they